

SENATE No.

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

PRESENTED BY:

Patrick M. O'Connor

To the Honorable Senate and House of Representatives of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts in General Court assembled:

The undersigned legislators and/or citizens respectfully petition for the adoption of the accompanying bill:

An Act creating a behavioral health emergency response pilot program.

PETITION OF:

NAME:

Patrick M. O'Connor

DISTRICT/ADDRESS:

First Plymouth and Norfolk

SENATE No.

By Mr. O'Connor, a petition (accompanied by bill) (subject to Joint Rule 12) of Patrick M. O'Connor for legislation to create a behavioral health emergency response pilot program. Public Safety and Homeland Security.

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act creating a behavioral health emergency response pilot program.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 Chapter 6A of the General Laws shall be amended by inserting the following new
2 section:-

3 Section 18AA. (a) The executive office of public safety and security, in collaboration
4 with the department of public health and the department of mental health, shall establish and
5 provide regulatory and administrative oversight to the behavioral health emergency response
6 pilot program, a co-response pilot program to increase the availability of behavioral health
7 clinicians to assist municipal police, fire and emergency medical professionals in emergency
8 response of 911 calls.

9 (b)(1) The program shall establish an application process for seeking a grant and
10 participating in the pilot program, criteria for municipal applicants, criteria for behavioral health
11 clinician staff, a process for determining approval for a grant application, and a data collection
12 system to understand outcomes of the co-response pilot program, including but not limited to the

number of individuals served, the demographics including age, gender, race, and ethnicity of individuals served, the number and types of emergency calls, the number of emergency calls requiring behavioral health clinician intervention, and behavioral health resources provided to individuals served.

(b)(2) The program shall collaborate with a board of community-based behavioral health organizations. The board shall include the executive director of the national alliance on mental illness Massachusetts or a designee, the president of the association for behavioral healthcare or a designee, the executive director of the Massachusetts chapter of the national association of social workers or a designee, the director of greater Boston association of black social workers or a designee, the director of the Massachusetts peer support network or a designee, the director of the western Massachusetts learning community or designee, and the president of the Massachusetts league of community health centers or a designee.

(d) Behavioral health clinician staff shall not respond to an emergency call without a municipal police, fire or emergency medical professional.

(e) The program shall establish an educational program for municipal police, fire and emergency medical professionals in the areas of behavioral health, community policing and serving individuals with disabilities.

(f) The program shall report not later than 12 months after the effective date of this act and annually thereafter to the house and senate committees on ways and means, the joint committee on public health, and the joint committee on public safety and homeland security. The report shall include but not be limited to an outline of grant allocation, the number of municipal department participants, the number of behavioral health clinician staff, the data results of the

- 35 pilot program, identified barriers to establishing and maintaining the program and response
- 36 measures taken to promote public safety.